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Henry Johnson

Henry Johnson is one of a rare breed of musicians who moves comfortably between the world of classic jazz and the current contemporary jazz scene. The Chicago-born guitarist has worked with the likes of Stanley Turrentine, Jimmy Smith, Ramsey Lewis and currently travels with the quartet that accompanies vocalist Joe Williams. He has recorded three albums for MCA/Impulse and can be heard on his latest record "New Beginnings" for Heads Up Records, where he adds his vocal and composing skills to his formidable guitar playing.

Henry was interviewed by Michael Woods on a Royal Caribbean jazz cruise on May 30, 1995.

MW: Hello. We are on board the Royal Caribbean cruise line and we are filming a Jazz Archive interview for Hamilton College. We have with us today as our guest Henry Johnson. Pleased to have you.

HJ: Nice to be here, Mike.

MW: Let me ask you a few questions about your guitar playing. First of all, I caught your set with Joe Williams, and two things I noticed about your playing. First of all it was really fine playing. I was excited to hear guitar playing that good, that clean, that crisp. But also, that marvelous blues influence in your playing. And it didn't matter what type of tune it was. There was that authenticity that only comes from a player who understands the blues.

HJ: Yeah, that's definitely there. It comes from experience and then too, I was raised in Chicago, and I spent some time in Memphis. In fact when I first started playing I was living in Memphis, Tennessee, and as you know Memphis is the home of B.B. King and a lot of other people, so I came up listening to the blues and Gospel music. And in Chicago, a lot of the blues players migrated from the South to Chicago. So I was still getting the same thing. And all around Chicago any night of the week you can go hear blues. And I just always loved that, the blues first, and I felt that anything that you play should have some sort of feeling in it, no matter what kind of tune it is. So that always got instilled in me, and by Joe being the great blues singer that he is, it always comes out with him. He does the same thing. He can sing blues sophisticated, but it always has that tendency to make you believe what he's saying.

MW: You know I wanted to ask you, how did you get started playing the guitar? Who were you listening to at that time or who influenced you or what made you want to be a musician?

HJ: Well you know when I first started playing the guitar I was just 14 or 13, and a friend of mine who had a guitar laying around his house all the time, we used to just go around and

play around with the chords or something like that. But my grandfather was a guitar player in the church. So we played in all of the Gospel churches around the South. And I really never thought about playing the guitar, it was just something to do. When I got to be about 13-1/2, I started listening to records, to blues records and Gospel records, and I was playing with Gospel groups. So the Gospel groups, even though it was one group, they were playing in a different church every Sunday. And so by doing that I got drenched with the Gospel stuff too. But the Gospel and the blues is so close that it just adds more to it to me. And after that I was playing in an R&B band, by the time I got to be 14 I was playing in an R&B band which was playing with Isaac Hayes. So that was my first professional gig. And after that, while I was with that band, the bass player brought a record of Wes Montgomery — "Tequila" — and from then on I was listening and I said well what is this, I never heard this, and this is jazz? There was no place around Memphis at that time for me to hear jazz. So I got it strictly through records. So I got that record, and then everybody that was on that record I went and got their records. And then everybody that was on those records, I went and got those records, so it exploded. And after that I started really listening to a lot of jazz, and wanted to play just jazz. And then my family moved back north to Chicago, and it was sort of like Gary, Indiana, was like 35 miles away from Chicago. So I grew up there the rest of the time, and went to high school in Gary. But in the meantime I met another guy who was a jazz piano player in Gary, by the name of Billy Foster. And so he lived right around the corner from me so that was like right home from school, into my room, practice, and run over to Billy's house, because he had all the records. He had Ahmad Jamal, Miles, he had everybody. So through him I had a chance to learn about other artists that I didn't know anything about. And I just got entrenched in jazz. And by that time I started playing out around, and I played with him. He had a group for about three years and we just played around Gary and the Chicago area. And then after that I had my own little trio, which I would do all kinds of contemporary music, because at that time you had to play the blues and contemporary music, and everything else to work.

MW: Now I want to ask you something about a guitar trio. That is, that really takes some kind of player, because you think of a trio you think of a keyboard player, because he can play chords with his left hand and he can solo with his right hand. So he can kind of comp behind himself. But with you just, what'd you have just bass and drums? That's a lot of work.

HJ: I was too young to know it was a lot of work. I mean you know when I started doing the songs of the day at that time, was "Bet You By Golly Wow" and all that kind of stuff, I didn't know that was a lot of work. So what I did was I hired a singer, a female singer, who, she sang half of the show and I played the other half. And it was odd because I

never missed a piano player at that time. But later on when I started, after that I was working with a big band that worked all of the society functions, Morris Allen, who still has a big band now today, and through that I started really getting, I always liked big band music, and when I was in Memphis I also played clarinet. Because I wanted to play trumpet but they didn't have a trumpet then so the only thing they had left was the clarinet so I played the clarinet so I could be in the band, in the junior high school band. And I got introduced to classical music. But our band teacher was a jazz piano player around Memphis. So he always was in his office playing standards on the lunch hour. So it's really funny how all the things work out. Now he ended up being the head of the University of Nevada. I finally searched him out and found where he was about five years ago. And so I've kept up with him since then.

MW: You know I wanted to ask you a question, a couple of things here because you've got this marvelous mix and a lot of players I find have this mix. And it doesn't get talked about that much in jazz history books, but you know, a lot of the jazz historians want to treat jazz as if it's just jazz. But when I've talked to so many players, particularly to African American players that said, wait a minute, I got church background. I heard Gospel music when I was a kid, you know? Just give us an example of how the sound of the Gospel music goes into your playing — how that breathes some type of new life or conviction into your playing.

HJ: Well I think it is because the Gospel music is so closely linked with the blues. You know they talk about the same thing — give me a break. You know I mean how much blues can I take, how much, you know torment can I take, give me a break somebody. So in the Gospel music it's give me a break, God, you know? And in the blues, give me a break period, somebody, you know?

MW: One guy said it like this, he said the only difference between Gospel and rhythm & blues is one guy is talking about God and the other guy's talking about his girlfriend.

HJ: Exactly.

MW: The one guy's talking about God loves me and he's going help me, and the other one is talking about a woman left me and don't care.

HJ: Yeah, Joe has the blues that he sings, he says, "You don't love me, but then, I don't even care. 'Cause I'll find a good girl somewhere." So it seems to be that they are closely linked. And I don't know, I think because you become a product of your environment so to speak, you can't be in an environment and not be affected by it in some sort of way. So your age has a lot to do with it too. Because I was playing music that was a lot older and more mature than, you know 13 years old, 15 years old. So I hung around older guys all the time. I figured the young guys didn't have nothing to teach me. They didn't know any more than I did.

MW: Well you know we've interviewed several musicians and every one of them has said, you know if you get a chance play with somebody that's better than you. Jump in over your head.

HJ: Exactly.

MW: So that you learn forms that you didn't know, you learn chord changes you didn't know, you learn voicings you didn't know, you know? And you learn styles and maturity and how to caress the sound.

HJ: Well I, to me, that's exactly true. To me I think that each guy is a school unto himself, each one of the older guys who I consider masters. And it's oddly enough, a lot of them don't even consider themselves masters. But us younger players we do, because they have reached a level of maturity and proficiency that we just aspire to reach.

MW: Give us some of the guitar icons.

HJ: Well when I came up, the first one like I said the first one I was listening to was Wes Montgomery and then from there I listened to Kenny Burrell and from there there was Pat Martino and then in the 70s I finally got some records by George Benson and I heard him and I said, "Oh, no!" But after a while you go through all the guitar players, there are things that are being done on the instrument and after a while you can say okay, that's how it's done. But I'm at a point, I've reached the point where I'm stretching harmonic boundaries, things that are not usually done on the guitar. And usually those people don't listen to guitar players to get that extra oomph. You know George Benson got a chance to hang around with Herbie Hancock and Freddie Hubbard and Joe Henderson and all those guys, so his harmonic concept exploded, because he's listening to instruments other than just guitar. And he listened to a lot of guitar players. But I found myself being affected by a lot of piano players and saxophone players and trumpet players. I love trumpet, because that's what I wanted to play originally.

MW: Do you find yourself when you solo when you play your lines, do you find yourself phrasing like a wind player?

HJ: Yeah. Yeah, I think because if you don't everything ends up sounding like an exercise. You have to breathe life into the phrase by actually putting air into it and breathing with it. And that's what a lot of the guys that are coming out of schools now, they don't realize, they work with a lot of transcribed solos. But when you look at a solo on a piece of paper without actually listening to it being done, you don't really correlate why a guy did this, you know? You see a weird note on there and you think oh, that's just his idea. He did that weird note because of something that the piano player played or something the drummer played or the bass player played. It was the interaction, and that didn't come out on the transcribed solo.

MW: You know I was trans — not transcribing but looking at a transcribed solo, one of Dizzy's solos. And I was looking at the chord changes, and then I was looking at the notes. And I said there are so many wrong notes on there. I said there's more wrong notes than there is right notes. If you look at it stagnantly on paper, there's a ton of wrong notes. But if you listen to it at speed it's exciting because he can play with such authority, that he can take all them wrong notes and sell them to you.

HJ: Well see the thing is, there is no wrong note if it's followed by a right one.

MW: Or if it's put in context.

HJ: Yeah because it's only a way of getting there. What you're looking at is the end result, and you might find a bunch of different ways to get there, and a bunch of different roads, but they all end up at the same spot. And I think that the ways that people get there is their own, that's their identification. Say like McCoy has a different way if you're just taking a regular two five, McCoy has a different way of getting there; Herbie Hancock has a different way of getting there, but that way of getting there that's the excitement that makes them their own person. We can look at a Basie two five. A lot of guys approaching two five as okay, we'll play on the minor seventh chord, then we'll play on the seventh chord, then we'll play on the major chord. But Herbie has a technique of playing on the five, which, and I heard this with McCoy first. They're playing on the five chord and then they'll go up and play on the sharp five chord and come back down. Well Herbie plays on the five, goes up to the sharp five, and extends it and stays on there until the last half of the beat of the four, and he hangs over. So after the one, the downbeat of the next bar of the one chord, he comes in after and relieves the tension. So when I was studying McCoy and listening to a lot of McCoy's, it's about tension and release. You know you keep building up tension after tension until you find, you finally get release.

MW: Or build tension in such a way that you have the option to either fulfill or disguise.

HJ: Yeah. Or disappoint.

MW: Or disappoint if you want to. I want to ask you, tell me about what it's like to be a guitarist accompanying behind Joe Williams.

HJ: It's a learning situation all the time and it's an enjoyment because you never know what's going to happen. Joe has been and done so many things he's forgotten more stuff that most people know. And I mean you know, you never know when you're on stage and one of those things are going to come out. He keeps us cracking up all the time. And while you're cracking up, you have to still be on your toes. So it's like a real frenetic type of thing going on all the time. But it's been one of the most enriching experiences of my life, playing with him because he made me see that without the lyrics of the song, you can't really go out and play a song. Because you don't know what it's about. So if you go out and play, you know "Stella By Starlight" just by the notes of the melody, it really

doesn't mean that much to you. Because you don't know the little story that's behind it. So he told me also that most of the guys that were coming up in the 40s and 50s, all the musicians knew the lyrics to the songs. That's how come they could play a ballad so great. Because they knew the story that's behind it. And the kids coming up now they don't learn the lyrics to the songs. They just learn the melody and then they go and play it. But it's a song that's not connected with any personal experience they have because they don't know the story that's behind it.

MW: You know something else that bothers me is like a lot of the songs that are out today, I don't know that the lyrics are worth knowing.

HJ: There's no stories behind those.

MW: There's very few stories and it seems like people just make a record to see if they can sell, how many pieces of plastic they can sell but it seems to be lacking in authenticity. I want to ask you about something else, because I know that Joe is a master of this. And then I want to see how that affects your guitar playing. And that is you know when a person sings or plays and they are knowledgeable about the effect that their music is having culturally, the music seems to come from a different place inside of them than just because they know the chord or the scale that goes with that.

HJ: Yeah, I agree with you. I agree with you yeah. It does make a great difference.

MW: You know you talk about for instance you talk about knowing the lyrics. But also it's like if the music is expensive to you, if that costs you something, experientially, to embody that. You know you talk about the blues. You know, well you know if a guy pulls up in his Ferrari Testarossa, you know, at his girl friend's house, it's going to be hard for him to sing the blues and convince me. You know what I'm saying? I don't know if he ever had the blues. He might know the twelve bar progression. You know what I'm saying? Now give us an example of that, or how that, working with Joe has given you any of those examples.

HJ: Well, that's sort of intrinsic to point out. But most all the blues were written about, or written from somebody's experience. And since we are all human beings, no matter what color you are or where you're from, you're going to experience some pain and sorrow in your life because that is a part of living. You know those things happen to us to learn how to deal with our emotions. And musicians have a great outlet for that. You know we can deal with ours just by singing about it and telling you about it, and then it doesn't make us feel so bad. But the poor people that are not musicians and they're just day to day, they don't have an outlet for that. So that's where we come in. So they can listen to us and identify with something that just happened to them, and they'll say, well I guess I'm not the only one. It doesn't make them feel lonely anymore, like they're the only one that this would happen to. I mean there's a lot of times when we're out there and we're playing

shows, and Joe will sing a song and people, I just see people melt. Because they identify with it right away. And it just makes you feel like you're a part of the whole and not an outsider and out there by yourself. You know and I think that has a great effect on everything in society. So we were talking about something the other day about this school program. I remember when I came up in school, music was an integral part and the arts were an integral part of everything. And by them trying to cut that out now I think is one of the greatest sins they could do.

MW: Let me ask you this question. Because I asked somebody else this. And I'm going to make a statement and then you just kind of jump in on it. That is, you know the guy that set the bomb in Oklahoma City? I don't think that that guy could have done that if he had even that same morning listened to a Mozart or a Mendelssohn symphony or listened to a couple of good tracks by Ellington.

HJ: That's right. I agree with you there. I mean there's certain kinds of music that will pull up that violent nature in you. I won't mention any names, but there are those musics out there. And then there's other musics that soothe you and make you feel like you're a part of everybody. And the ones that make you feel like you're a part of everybody would never make you do those kinds of things.

MW: And now here's something else that I would like you to talk about. You talked about your Gospel experience. You talked about your rhythm & blues experience. You talked about the blues making a person not feel alone. And then when I think of jazz I think of probably the most sophisticated improvisatory music in the world that's been lifted to the level of an art form. But to me, it still develops this communal effect. Like when I go to a black Gospel church. And sometimes even if it's a preacher that I don't like, if the soprano is singing real good, why I've already got my message. You know what I mean? And that can give me a sense of community. And make me feel a part of a whole. Just one sometimes can do that for me. And have you played your guitar and seen that happen in an audience? Just without your conversing with them. They don't know anything about you, they just hear you play your guitar and that gives that sense of community.

HJ: Yeah. I see it happen all the time in most places that I play. And I don't know if I'm doing it or — I think that the Creator of us all is using musicians as a tool to let that goodness flow through. You know and if we take our egos out of the way, it just comes through and hits you and creates something for you. You know you identify with it. For me I know that I've been in certain situations where I was playing on stage and people were sitting up front. And I know that this guy probably was, him and his lady were fighting before they got there. Because he probably didn't want to pay the cover charge or something like that you know? But the moment that we hit one of those songs he starts, a smile on his face, starts tapping his feet [inaudible] And when they left there they

were smiling and he was really happy that he came, because the music made him feel good, along with her. So it changes people. It's a universal language that no matter what country we go in, whether they speak the language or not, the music is the language that everybody speaks.

MW: You know speaking of language, I'll share this with you and then I want you to give me one of your examples. Sometimes you know I will go to hear a great musician. And I won't know the person personally. But they'll be up there playing and of course I'm a musician so I'll say to myself, okay now I need him to go on up in the register right now. Soon as I think that he goes up there and starts burning. I said now he's playing a million notes. Not I need him to back off on that technique and just give me a blues lick. And just about that time he'll cut off them power techniques and play something funky and bluesy. And I go now this guy's reading my mind, you know? He's giving me just what I want when I want it. And then, you know he'll finish the song or maybe if I listen to a set then I'll say I almost feel like I've had a conversation with that person. You know because the music is language.

HJ: Yeah it is. I think so too. It's because you're a musician and you speak the same language. And you're thinking the way they will be thinking because you are both tapped into that creative flow. See even when you don't have your axe in your hand, you're still playing, you know? Because your mind is the thing that plays. The instrument could be a block of wood or anything else, the instrument just goes in your hand to get out what's in your mind. And so even when you're watching somebody else, your mind is still playing. And you're both tapped into the same thing. I do the same thing all the time. I sense that too you know. So I know exactly what you're talking about.

MW: I want to ask you a question now about working with Basie. From the standpoint of a guitar player, I want you to tell us how that almost now patented Freddie Green kind of guitar playing helped that incredible Basie rhythm section.

HJ: Now see, when I got a chance to work with Basie, Freddie was still around, but Basie wasn't playing anymore, because he was kind of sick. But by working with the band all the other guys were still there. And Freddie Green came through, I was working in Chicago with Joe. And he came after their show and sat down and listened to us. And he came up to me. I knew who he was, but I didn't think he knew who I was. And he came up to me and he really enjoyed my guitar playing. So we became friends. And I always asked him, "Freddie, you know the type of guitar that you're playing is not documented, you know you've got to do something with the style to leave it on to the rest of the folks." And he said, "Okay, okay, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah." And he never got around to doing it. And right before he left us he was talking about doing it, because I told him different ways to do it now, and he doesn't have to write down anything, he can just do it right into

a computer, and you know it'll go right up on the screen. And so when I finally convinced him to do that then he left us. But the style that, when I first saw the Basie band, Freddie's style was more felt than heard, you know? And when you listened for it you could hear it. Because it was like the pulse of the band. It was pumping the band all of the time. And at any time that you could decipher each instrument, you know what each instrument was doing, you could always hear Freddie Green. And when you hear all the other instruments you could always feel them. He was like the pulse of the whole band, right along with the drummer. And that style of playing is no longer, not the way that he did it, it's no longer with us. Now the guy that plays with the Basie band now, I think his name is T.J., he is very good at what he does too. But there is only one Freddie Green. And so I will always remember him as you know, joking with him and getting him to admit that he needs to do this, and he never did, but still he was a great human being. He was always very complimentary and always uplifting.

MW: I want to ask you, can you delineate for us if I'm having some students that are going to be watching this video. Tell us some differences between, like in terms of your tone quality and of the volume, and maybe even what you do in the left hand, between jazz guitar playing and rock guitar playing. Now I will tell you this. I met a rock guitar player. I was in a music store trying out an instrument and he was in there kind of banging away with big bar chords and stuff. And I told him, you know, you need to listen to some jazz guitar players. I saw the guy again a little later, and he says, "Man I'm really beginning to like jazz now." He says, "Now I know all the notes that were missing." But give us some examples of differences between jazz and rock.

HJ: Well, jazz is like to me it's probably the ultimate music to play because it's the type of music that you can find your own identity in. Rock & roll, they use a lot of the loud guitars, and a lot of distortion. And the distortion is exactly what it says, it distorts the tone. So with jazz I'm looking for the purest tone I can get. Because that's going to allow my own identity to come out in that in the dynamics. When I work with Joe, and playing jazz on my own, the music to me has to have peaks and valleys. Because you don't breathe the same way all of the time. You don't feel the same way all of the time. So music to me should not start here, continue here and end here. Then it's just very flat. But you know if it starts here and it goes here and it goes down here and goes here and goes there, that's the dynamics in the music. That's what made Ahmad Jamal so great and Oscar Peterson, you know? All of those kind of groups. They all had dynamics. Even classical music has dynamics written in it. You know because the dynamics is part of your flowing emotions. And as far as playing the guitar, the dynamics, I find, for myself, is in my picking hand. I can pick soft, I can pick loud. But if my guitar is this loud, so it allows me to play harder, to play softer, to play middle, to play down the middle of the

beat. I can do all of those things just by doing this with my hand and my arm. But the rock players, they just crank it up and that's where it is. And it stays that way the whole night. Pounding, pounding, pounding your ear. And to me, music should caress you and move you in different parts and make you go on different adventures, and you can't do that without dynamics.

MW: You know one professor that I studied with, he basically he said, you know he said let's say you're getting ready to play over this dominant seven with a flat nine or a sharp nine. And you're getting ready to play symmetric diminished half step whole step. He said, don't play the whole scale two octaves. In other words he said we know you know the scale, he said, hint at it and then give the audience some place to enter the music. Let the thing breathe long enough for them to enter. Because if they're listening, you know, you try to create this give and take. But like you said, in musics where the volume is too loud, the beat is always too insistent and force that you never imply but always state it, then sometimes the listener doesn't have a chance to participate.

HJ: Well a lot of times too, if like when I'm out on the road with Freddie Hubbard, and I always bug him because I want to know everything. And Freddie told me this himself, if you notice the thing about Freddie, he has the command to go either way. But he prefers to phrase. Because phrasing is like talking to somebody. You know if you're going to play on that dominant seven flat five, why play a scale? You know the scale that it goes with, so why play [scats]. That really doesn't mean anything except that you know what notes go on that chord. But if you play [scats] and they you answer somebody, and you're talking, you're conversing with the rest of the band, somebody in the band is going to answer you. And it becomes a constant conversation all the time, and the listeners get a chance to come into the fold because they are also becoming a part of the conversation. So you know I sort of think in phrases because when you're singing, you're singing in phrases. You've got to take a breath sometime. So I just think breath. And if I think breath, I know that people relate, because they breathe too.

MW: I've got a definition I want to ask you about. Because this is kind of elusive, but you just give us your own words. You know playing rhythm guitar, setting up sometimes counter rhythms. If the bass is walking quarter notes, and sometimes you have to drop chords and spaces all around without, without, sometimes without doing the Freddie Green thing on every beat. But can you give us your definition of what you would call groove. What is groove?

HJ: It's called a lot of things. It's called groove, it's called pocket, it's called just like right on it. But I think groove is the feel when everything moves right together. It's like the bass player is the water, the piano player is the part of the boat, and the guitar player is like deck one, and the singer is at the helm. And all of you are just sailing and you're on the

groove. Everybody just sails right along and you can feel it. There's another thing that I got from Joe, and singers in general, but he told me that, you know, when he was coming up that music was for dancing. And we sort of got away from that. And when calls off a tempo, and a lot of guys, when they get ready to call off a tempo of a song, they're always thinking about where you would dance to it. And every time, without fail, for the last 28 years that I have seen the old guys call off the tempo of a song, people immediately start moving their bodies right away. Because those guys knew that the music was for dancing. And there is a certain rhythm or a certain tempo that the body just moves with, you know. It's not jerky or anything like that, it just grooves right along and Joe has it. I mean he does it all of the time. And I notice this all the time, because he was right, music is for dancing, you know, when they were coming up. But I think that we got real, when the avante garde stuff came and stuff like that it lost the audience. Because they couldn't relate to it, and they couldn't feel it either, you know? I think that you can probably get away with a lot of stuff if you just swing like mad. But when you don't have that, and you're not swinging either, it loses people.

MW: Didn't Ellington say something about that?

HJ: That's right. If it don't have that swing, you know, what's it about.

MW: I want to ask you a closing question here. If you had a word to the wise — for students of guitar coming up, or basic just for in terms of jazz appreciation, just the average lay person listening to jazz, wanting to appreciate the music more. Could you give them some handles to kind of start with, to kind of get into the music, to appreciate it and add it to their sound palette?

HJ: Well you know what I find as people get older, their taste it starts to taste different. And they start to mature. And jazz is a music that they go to automatically. And I don't know why that is, it's just that I think that when they're teenagers they listen to this, but they get tired of that because there's nothing left of it, and it's a fad. And so they start listening to mom and pop's records and they find stuff in there they like because they've never been exposed to it before. And once they're exposed to it it's such a variety of different stuff that you can find, I mean anybody can find something that they like. But I would just say for the average person that's just not a musician, I would say to listen to everything and try to listen to the experiences in the music — something that you can feel in the music. Because even if you don't understand it you can feel it. It has something that relates to you, and just listen for it. And the musicians themselves, you were asking me about what does, how would I do what for the musicians to give them a grasp —

MW: Just handles for how to appreciate and, and move into the music. And I think you've explained that quite well.

HJ: Yeah, I mean that's probably the basic thing I could say is just to listen, and the more you listen, it's coming to you later down the road. Two months later you say, wow, I know what that means, yeah. Or and it's just the music itself it's like being exposed to it, it creates a different atmosphere for you. And seeing it live really puts the icing on the cake. Because when you see how it's really done, you have a better appreciation for it.

MW: You know the reason why I like it live is because you know in a recording studio if you make a mistake you can always either just take it again, or erase — keep everybody else's good part and erase the guitar track for eight bars and then punch that back in or whatever you know. But I like it live when you count it off, you know you can't stop, even if you get out there burning taking some solo and get yourself painted into a corner, you've still got to get out of it, and get back into that chorus and hand the ball back to somebody else.

HJ: And see the thing too is the recording industry has changed to make perfect records. And perfect records are not musical. Because you work on this thing until, you know, eight bars okay now I got to go to the next eight bars. And that's really not a solo, that's not anything that you feel. That's something that you put together, you know, note by note. And you don't put solos together note by note because those are the experiences. You don't put those together note by note. The older, in the 50s and the 60s when they were recording records, you know there was no overdubs, you know. There was only four track recording, there was no overdubs. You do another take. And if you don't like that take, you're stuck with it. That's it.

MW: I even heard one musician say, he said if you don't have it after three takes, that's it. You just take the best of the three.

HJ: Yeah. And usually the first one is the one everybody goes for.

MW: I agree. Well, you know, we have been filming here for the Jazz Archive for Hamilton College. We've had a marvelous conversation here with Henry Johnson. Thank you very much.

HJ: Thank you, Mike.